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NATIONS PUSH DIPLOMACY TO END WAR

■ PAKISTAN EMERGES AS KEY MEDIATOR, READY TO HOST TALKS

■ INDIA ALSO JOINS CALLS FOR DE-ESCALATION AND PEACE

■ TWO POSSIBLE FORMATS FOR TALKS UNDER DISCUSSION

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Countries are intensifying diplomatic efforts to end the war, with Pakistan emerging as a potential key mediator and offering to host talks involving Iran, Israel and the United States.

Diplomatic activity has shifted into high gear after US President Donald Trump claimed on Monday that Iran was in talks to end the conflict — a claim Tehran has denied.

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said yesterday that Islamabad was prepared to facilitate negotiations aimed at halting the war, amid mounting speculation over its role as a go-between.

"Pakistan welcomes and fully supports ongoing efforts to pursue dialogue to end the war in the Middle East, in the interest of peace and stability in the region and beyond," Sharif wrote on X.

"Subject to concurrence by the US and Iran, Pakistan stands ready and honoured to host and facilitate meaningful and conclusive talks for a comprehensive settlement of the ongoing conflict," he added.

UAE Presidential Court

■ President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan yesterday received Catherine Vautrin, Minister of the Armed Forces and Veterans Affairs of France. The meeting discussed cooperation between the two countries in defence affairs and also addressed the ongoing military escalation in the Middle East and its implications for regional and international security.

Negotiation table

The diplomatic push comes as multiple countries ramp up outreach. Turkey's foreign minister has spoken to more than a dozen regional and global counterparts over the past 48 hours, while the president of the European Commission said yesterday it was "time to go to the negotiation table and end the hostilities" in Iran.

India also joined the calls for de-escalation. Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he had a "useful exchange of views" with Trump and stressed that India supports "de-escalation and restoration of peace at the earliest." He also underlined the need to keep the Strait of Hormuz "open, secure and accessible."

Backchannel communication

Tehran has signalled that backchannel communication may already be underway. Iran's foreign ministry said on Monday that messages had been received from "some friendly countries indicating a US request for negotiations to end the war."

Sharif also spoke with Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian, reiterating Pakistan's willingness to help broker peace, while Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar confirmed he had been in contact with his Iranian counterpart Abbas Araghchi.

Earlier, Pakistan's foreign ministry spokesman Tahir Hussain Andrabi told AFP that the country was "always willing to host talks" and had "consistently advocated for dialogue and diplomacy to promote peace and stability in the region."

Talks in Oman

Behind the scenes, there are indications of deeper engagement. Pakistan's former ambassador to Oman, Imran Ali Chaudhry, told *92 News* that Chief of Defence Forces and Chief of Army Staff Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir had held undisclosed talks in Oman with US officials. "Around two to two-and-a-half weeks ago, Field Marshal Asim Munir went to Oman on a trip that was not disclosed and he held a four-hour meeting with (Steve) Witkoff and (Jared) Kushner," he said.

Multiple US and Israeli media outlets have reported that Pakistan, along with Egypt and Turkey, has been acting as a conduit between Washington and Tehran, relaying messages in an effort to broker an off-ramp in a conflict that has triggered one of the most severe energy crises in modern times.

Islamabad in focus

Some reports suggest Islamabad could emerge as the venue for talks later this week. According to Axios, two possible formats are under discussion: One involving Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, US envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner; another envisioning US Vice-President JD Vance meeting Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf. Qalibaf has dismissed Trump's claims of talks, describing them as an attempt to "escape the quagmire in which the US and Israel are trapped."

Qatar has also weighed in, stressing the need for diplomacy while distancing itself from mediation efforts. Foreign Ministry spokesperson Majed Al Ansari said "the war must be ended through diplomatic means" and urged parties to reach the negotiating table.

Even as diplomatic momentum builds, the conflict continues to exact a toll across the region. The UAE Ministry of Defence said a Moroccan national working as a civilian contractor with the UAE Armed Forces was killed during a routine mission in Bahrain following an Iranian missile attack. Five UAE personnel were also injured in the strike.

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